When victorious, the Mongols were totally ruthless in their treatment of enemy combatants and often of whole civilian populations. Their reputation for terror grew with their conquests. Genghis invaded northern China in 1211 and had seized what is now Beijing by 1215, although rich and populous southern China remained for the time under the rule of the Song dynasty. In 1218 the Mongols attacked the powerful Kwaresmian Empire in central Asia, apparently after its shah offended Genghis by killing two traders who enjoyed the khan's protection. The campaigns that followed laid waste the famous cities of Samarkand and Bokhara, and many other historic cities, some of which would never recover their former glory.

GENGHIS'S LEGACY

The death of Genghis in 1127 did not check the course of destruction and expansion. In the 1230s Genghis's son Ogetai sent his armies further west. The Mongol general Subotai overran Russia, sacking Moscow in 1238. In 1240 it was the turn of the Ukraine, with the destruction of the venerable city of Kiev – a European traveller visiting Kiev five years later found "an enormous number of skulls and bones of slaughtered men lying on the plain" and "barely 200 houses standing". In 1241 Subotai led his Mongol forces into Poland and Hungary, defeating armies of European knights at the battles of Liegnitz and Mohi. Since the heavily armoured Christian cavalry had proved utterly incapable of coping with the speed of manoeuvre of the Mongol horsemen, nothing stood in the way of a Mongol conquest of western Europe. The Mongols were approaching Vienna when, by what Christian Europe regarded as a miracle, news arrived of the death of Ogetai. The Asian horsemen turned back, heading home to take part in the selection of a new leader. They never progressed as far westward again.



Decorated quiver
Mongol warriors were taught the use of the composite bow from an early age. A quiver was a crucial part of their armoury.

> "A SAVAGE PEOPLE, HELLISH OF ASPECT, AS VORACIOUS AS WOLVES IN THEIR HUNGER FOR SPOILS … BRAVE AS LIONS…"
>
> **QUEEN RUSSUDAN OF GEORGIA** DESCRIBING THE MONGOLS

CHANGING METHODS

The Mongols' relationship to the countries they subjugated was not, however, a purely destructive one. They benefited from the skills of states with a higher level of technological development. From the time of his very first campaign in China, Genghis became aware of the limitations of his tribal horsemen. Faced with the fortified defences of Chinese cities, they needed to acquire the techniques and machinery for siege warfare. It was almost certainly through employing Chinese expertise and personnel that the Mongol army was able to deploy rams and mangonels – heavy stone-throwing catapults – in the successful siege of Beijing in 1214-15. From that time onward a siege train was often attached to Mongol forces, and Chinese or Muslim engineers regularly put their specialist skills at the service of the khans.

BAGHDAD MASSACRE

It was thanks to this proficiency in siege warfare that in 1258 a Mongol army led by Hulegu was able to capture Baghdad, the seat of the Islamic Abbasid Caliphate. Almost the entire population of the city was massacred, including the Caliph himself. To the delight of Christian Crusaders, who were at that time struggling to keep a presence in Palestine, this victory seemed to open up the Muslim Arab world for Mongol conquest. Syria fell to Hulegu in 1259, which left only the Mamluks of Egypt to defy Mongol power. But the Mongols

Born warriors
As most Mongol warriors fought as horsemen they wore leather body armour for ease of movement. Warriors formed a close bond with their horse, which was important in the heat of battle.